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Lydén, Hilkka; Juujärvi, Soile; Miettinen, Satu

Published in:
DRS2026

DOI:
10.21606/drs.2026.695

Published: 01.01.2026

Document Version
Publisher's PDF, also known as Version of record

Citation for pulished version (APA):
Lydén, H., Juujärvi, S., & Miettinen, S. (2026). Designing with care: proposing an ethical canvas for co-design with marginalised groups. In L. Simeone, C. M. Gray, A. Verhoeven, A. de Götzen, Y. Bakırlıoğlu, H. Zohar, M. Stead, & P. Buwert (Eds.), DRS2026: Edinburgh, 8–12 June, Edinburgh, United Kingdom (pp. 1-15). Design Research Society. https://doi.org/10.21606/drs.2026.695

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Hilkka Lydén
Laurea University of Applied Sciences, Finland; University of Lapland, Finland

Soile Juujärvi
Laurea University of Applied Sciences, Finland; University of Helsinki, Finland

Satu Miettinen
University of Lapland, Finland

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Designing with care: proposing an ethical canvas for co-design with marginalised groups

Hilkka Lydén[ac]*, Soile Juujärvi[ab] and Satu Miettinen[c]

[a]Laurea University of Applied Sciences, Finland
[b]University of Helsinki, Finland
[c]University of Lapland, Finland

*Corresponding author e-mail: hilkka.lyden@laurea.fi

doi.org/10.21606/drs.2026.695

Abstract: This paper addresses gaps in ethical guidance for socially oriented designers engaged in co-design with marginalised groups. It introduces an ethical canvas for planning and evaluating co-design, developed through a collaborative inquiry led by a practitioner-researcher with long experience in community-based design. The canvas was informed by the authoring team's expertise in service design, ethical decision-making, and socially engaged design research. It makes ethical deliberation visible and actionable, especially where multiple or conflicting values are present. The canvas invites designers to reflect on their stance, engage with participants' lived realities, and navigate tensions between institutional expectations and situated needs. It supports the recognition of values such as autonomy, empowerment, social responsibility and social change, often implicit in practice. Ethics is approached as relational and evolving, shaped through dialogue and shared experience, across all levels of society. This contribution strengthens ethical decision-making and offers a practical tool for value-sensitive reflection.

Keywords: social co-design; ethical decision-making; ethical canvas; marginalised groups

1. Introduction

Ethics in everyday life refers to moral principles governing a person's behaviour or the conducting of an activity (Oxford English Dictionary). Moral principles people hold are realised through ethical action comprising four components: ethical sensitivity, ethical judgment, ethical motivation, and implementation (Rest & Narváez, 1994; Rest et al., 1999). These components are also involved in ethically sound design work. First, the designer must recognise ethical issues in ambiguous real-life contexts. Second, they must judge which of the potential lines of action would be most justified according to relevant moral or ethical standards. Third, they must prioritise ethical values over other competing values or states. Fourth, they have to implement their ethical decision into action, that is, to do what they judge to be right (Rest & Narváez, 1994).

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According to the current view in moral psychology, the above-mentioned order of the components is logical rather than temporal, but each component is inevitable for ethical action to occur. Multiple forms of knowledge and skills contribute to each component. Ethical sensitivity necessitates empathy and capability of imagining alternative future scenarios because of ethical choices, whereas ethical judgment requires knowledge of ethical values, principles, and theories that help to formulate ethically sound justifications for decisions. Ethical motivation requires commitment to ethical values, and finally, implementation of ethical decisions requires persistence, courage, and negotiation skills (Rest & Narváez, 1994). This indicates that the designer must be sensitive to participants' needs and acquire knowledge on their sociocultural and economic environments to understand their situations more fully. Participants often bear vulnerabilities originating from social group belongings, and there is a danger to stigmatise them incompetent, compromising ethical undertakings in design projects. It is therefore of crucial importance that the designer becomes aware of their values guiding their perception and decision-making and adopt ethical values that serve rights and wellbeing of participants in the co-design process. Values, defined as beliefs about what is regarded as worthy and valuable (Banks, 2012, p.8) pave way to desired states of affairs and provide a convenient tool to express and communicate one's views to other designers and build shared values for the professional community.

Design ethics has become increasingly important in designer's work. The systemic turn in design has involved designers working with more and more complex systems (Miettinen et. al. 2025). This has an impact on designer's role and capabilities. Design education has more consideration not only on design ethics but designers' ability to understand vulnerability and the pluriversal worldview (Miettinen et. al. 2022). Pluriversal understanding opens design thinking into multiple mindsets, realities, and value systems co-existing at the same time. To work with this kind of complexities demand both care and in-depth design ethics. This would propose care as a leading design principle that proposes attentiveness, responsibility, competence, and responsiveness as fundamental practices related to the caring process (Frigo et. al 2023).

This paper responds to a critical gap in ethical guidance for socially oriented designers working in co-design processes with marginalised groups. Grounded in work done in a university living lab and multiple EU-funded projects focused on supporting immigrants' integration through collaborative design activities, the paper argues that while methods such as workshops, interviews, and prototyping offer rich opportunities for empowerment and inclusion, they also raise complex ethical questions. These questions often remain unaddressed due to the absence of a structured tool for reflection and evaluation.

To address this, the paper introduces an ethical canvas for planning and evaluating co-design processes. Rather than prescribing fixed principles, the canvas helps designers make underlying decisions and values visible and work through tensions that arise when institutional expectations meet the lived priorities of participants. It aids in building trust between different actors, which is vital in co-design processes (Beaulé, 2025). It reveals values often overlooked in design discourse, such as power, dignity, reciprocity, and vulnerability, and offers a way to integrate these into practical decisions. In doing so, the canvas shifts the focus from technology-driven or top-down "tick-the-box" ethics toward approaches grounded in relational, embodied and systemic considerations.

Ethical reflection is never a solitary undertaking. This paper builds on Lydén's experience in socially engaged co-design. The ethical canvas is shaped through that practice and informed by theoretical perspectives, which are presented in detail in the theoretical background of this paper. The canvas was developed in close collaboration with co-authors who bring critical perspectives on design, various ethical approaches, and ethical decision-making. This partnership reflects the belief that ethical awareness deepens through dialogue.

We are inevitably limited in our ability to fully see and question our own assumptions. By opening this reflection to academic evaluation, the paper seeks not to offer definitive answers but to contribute to an ongoing conversation. It is an invitation for others to join in, challenge and extend the ethical discourse within design practice, especially in socially inspired co-design processes.

As part of this reflective inquiry, the authors find it important to make their ethical grounding and positionality explicit.

- **Hilkka Lydén**: My stance is shaped by values of hope, autonomy, social responsibility and equality. I believe in the possibility of change even in difficult circumstances, and in the right of individuals to define and influence what matters to them. I position myself as a highly educated, middle-class, able-bodied, white, Western CIS woman with a stable life situation, while also identifying as queer and belonging to a language minority. My professional background and theoretical orientation draw on feminist and critical theology, liberation ethics and norm-critical pedagogy, resonating with queer feminist ethics that emphasise relationality, vulnerability and the transformative power of hope.
- **Soile Juujärvi**: I am a middle aged, highly educated CIS woman with satisfying living conditions. My background is critical social psychology, and I am interested in both descriptive and normative aspects in ethics. Care and justice are guiding values in my personal and professional life. I grew up in a religious community connected with feelings of otherness and stigmatisation. I care a lot about people around me, especially my mother with Alzheimer's disease.
- **Satu Miettinen**: My ethical stance is shaped by the responsibility towards future generations. I'm a politically active member of my community, serving as a member of the education board. My values would propose activism for sustainable development, equality and equity. My position is privileged and enjoying social, economic, or systemic advantages from several aspects: high level of education, Caucasian, able-bodied, middle-class and in management position. I've been bullied for my cross-sightedness and obesity which have made me feel vulnerable from time to time. My understanding of the world is related to new material philosophy that acknowledges our material environment and intra-action with this, radical inclusion and non-binary or "*pluriversal*"thinking.

2. Theoretical background

2.1 Social co-design

Social design can mean several things, depending on the focus. Tonkinwise (Tonkinwise, 2015/2019) describes it as design that operates outside commercial imperatives, grounded in social science methodologies and committed to enabling socially transformative change. This understanding resonates with the ethical canvas proposed in this article. The canvas builds on the idea that design is never neutral. It is embedded in social relations and shaped by power structures. By framing co-design as a socially situated activity, the canvas encourages practitioners to recognise these dynamics and to make value choices explicit. Santonen (2021) distinguishes between participatory design, which involves intended service users, and collaborative design, which includes multiple stakeholders beyond users. Building on these distinctions, social co-design was introduced by Lydén et al. (2023) to describe processes that aim to influence social situations together with the people whose lives are affected and other relevant actors. Social co-design, from now on SCD, often involves participants from vulnerable groups, making ethical reflection not optional but essential. The proposed canvas is intended to support SCD by providing a structured way to plan, assess and negotiate values in these complex, multi-stakeholder contexts.

2.2 The ethics of care

The ethics of care is imperative for actions that aim to enhance wellbeing of vulnerable people. It acknowledges human encounter and affective response as a basic fact of human existence (Noddings, 1984) and contributes to needs-based social justice (Tronto, 1993). According to Noddings (1984), the ethics of care means attempting to meet the other morally, whereas Fisher and Tronto (1990, p. 40) define it in wider terms “as a species activity that includes everything that we do to maintain, continue, and repair our ’world’ so that we can live in it as well as possible”.

The ethics of care represents multidisciplinary approach, referring to both the nature of moral judgment verified in moral psychology (Gilligan, 1982) and the normative ethical theory originating from feminist philosophy (Noddings, 1984). The ethics of care builds on interdependence of people, responsiveness to others’ needs, and the contextual analysis of moral problems. It represents ‘particularistic’ moral reasoning, paying attention to specific features of people and situations and seeking best solutions to enhance the wellbeing of others through activities of care. The ethics of care is thus in sharp contrast with its counterpart, the ethics of justice, which represents ‘universalistic’ moral reasoning, aiming at establishing rules and moral principles to maintain fairness and justice (Blum, 1988; Juujärvi & Helkama, 2021). Hammington (2019) points out that the ethics of care and design thinking are analogous with relational and responsive dimensions and would benefit from each other. Concepts drawing on the ethics of care can shape design thinking forward, while its participatory processes can enable the approach to expand as a social and political ethic (Hammington, 2019). The ethics of care scholars regard people as basically vulnerable beings and see their empowerment as a political goal (e.g., Tronto, 1993) that coincides with our SCD thinking. The ethics of care is also closely linked to embodied ethics, because it emphasises ‘feeling with the other’ and ‘receiving the other into myself’ taking place in close interactions as critical for caring (Noddings, 2024, pp. 30, 33).

Fisher and Tronto (1990) have further defined the ethic of care as a four-phase process involving caring about, taking care of, caregiving, and care-receiving. *Caring about* means ethical sensitivity; staying attentive to features in our environments having influence on well-being. *Taking care of* deals with assuming responsibilities for initiating and maintaining caring activities, whereas *caregiving* means concrete work when meeting others' needs, requiring competence: experience, judgment, and practical skills. *Care-receiving* is defined as a confirmatory response to caregiving by those receiving care. Ethical cornerstones supporting the detailed caring process are attentiveness, responsibility, competence, and responsiveness (Fisher & Tronto, 1990; Tronto, 1993). This process is ideally reflected in the SCD processes, where the facilitators and participants mutually co-create through reciprocal acts of caring. It is mostly visible in the canvas's section on stewardship, but as an underlying principle it has informed all sections of the canvas.

2.3 Ethics of vulnerability

The canvas is intended to be used in co-design processes with socially marginalised people and those otherwise in vulnerable situations. By vulnerability we refer not only to physical or psychological fragility, but more broadly to also social and structural conditions that limit individuals' power, agency and access to resources. Individuals considered vulnerable are less empowered and therefore at risk of needing social or humanitarian support, as in the case of migration. We understand vulnerability as intersectional, shaped by overlapping and interdependent systems of inequality that lead to multiple forms of marginalisation. We understand vulnerability as dynamic and context-specific rather than a fixed attribute of demographic groups. Societal structures and power relations play a significant role in producing vulnerabilities, which can intensify during crises and disasters. (Florczak, 2020; Hodson et al., 2023; Kuran et al., 2020).

Gilson (2016) highlights that vulnerability is often automatically seen as a negative aspect associated with weakness, dependence, powerlessness, insufficiency, and passivity. Vulnerability is perceived as leading to poor outcomes. Therefore, invulnerability is valued and examining one's own vulnerability is not considered desirable. Gilson (ibid.) criticises this perspective. Addressing vulnerability, confronting it, and understanding its significance is an ethical question that requires contemplation. They challenge the normative definitions and meanings of vulnerability, where its ethical implications are overlooked. Truly understanding vulnerability challenges the normative idea of invulnerability as desirable and vulnerability as undesirable.

Gilson's (ibid.) idea of vulnerability feels personal and real. We are accustomed to not bringing forth our own vulnerability, especially when in leadership positions. Its exposure is perceived as bad and negative. Avoiding vulnerability in everyday actions leads us to seek invulnerability. This is emphasised by self-sufficiency, self-determination, autonomy, independence from others, and denial of susceptibility to influence, even though this is impossible. Vulnerability is distressing because it binds us to social positions and attributes seen as lower or less capable. Gilson (ibid.) suggests that we shape and manage our relationship to vulnerability to mould ourselves into invulnerable beings. According to them, the paradigm of invulnerability is related to the subjectivity of Western communities and capitalist thinking (ibid.).

These insights inform the ethical canvas by emphasising that vulnerability is not a deficit but a relational condition that shapes design encounters. The canvas provides a structured way to consider these dynamics when planning and assessing co-design activities, ensuring that ethical reflection accounts for power, dependency and the lived realities of participants.

2.4 Ethics of empowerment

Service users' empowerment is often understood as gaining confidence and personal power, but its original meaning involves striving for social change (Banks, 2012). The concept of empowerment is grounded in the principles of social justice and equity, representing a bottom-up approach that emphasises autonomy, agency, and the recognition of individual and collective strengths. Individuals and communities have the right to define their own needs and priorities. (Spencer, 2015, p. 206). Ethics of empowerment is derived from radical theories of social justice that see people as fundamentally social beings embedded in unequal positions in society. Social justice prioritises the equality in meeting needs to the equality in distribution of resources and aims to promote change towards correcting prevailing inequalities through empowerment (Banks, 2012). Spicker (1988, quoted in Banks, 2012) points out that equality in terms of social justice means 'the removal of disadvantage' in treatment, opportunities, and results. For example, the designer should advance real opportunities of participation for those having poor physical, cultural and language access to conventional design sessions, by picking up them, using interpreters and giving financial compensations among other things.

Empowerment can be understood in multiple ways. From an individual perspective, it refers to personal growth, skill-building, or the strengthening of self-esteem that enables people to make informed choices in their own lives. From a collective perspective, empowerment involves communities taking action to redress the negative effects of socio-political conditions on their wellbeing (Spencer, 2015, p. 206) and can enhance social participation, new connections and redistribution of resources in communities (Nelson & Prillelltensky, 2005) Likewise in participatory action research (Juujärvi & Lund, 2017), empowerment in the SCD context can be understood as growing critical awareness of one's own situation and capacity to act on that awareness (Lundy, 2005), and a process by which people and communities gain mastery over their lives (Rappaport, 1981).

When the social situation that the co-design process seeks to improve is due to lack of power in a context, empowerment seems to be the logical, ethical, and unproblematic solution. However, empowerment, whether as a goal or an approach, is never free from the underlying assumptions, values and principles directing the choices made during a process that seeks to empower. (Spencer, 2015, pp. 205–206).

Critical discussions of empowerment in health promotion have highlighted how professional framings of "empowerment" can mask deeper power asymmetries and differing understandings of well-being (Owens & Cribb, 2013; Spencer, 2015). Such reflections are equally relevant for co-design, where designers' assumptions about participation and improvement may inadvertently reproduce hierarchies rather than challenge them. Von Busch and Palmås describe this as the "corruption of co-design," in which design's idealism becomes complicit with the very systems of inequality it seeks to transform.

Designers are often portrayed as agents for improving the social situation in the world. Co-design is also idealistic both in motivation and reality. If the designer does not address deep social and ecological concerns and relies on a shallow definition of empowerment or the ethics of design problems, they are bound to continue enabling exploitation, injustices, class systems, and social status hierarchies. (Busch & Palmås, 2023, p. 10).

These reflections on empowerment inform the ethical canvas by highlighting that empowerment is not an uncontested good, but a process embedded in power relations, assumptions, and institutional constraints. The canvas prompts designers to question whose perspectives shape the goals of a co-design process and whose definitions of "improvement" or "benefit" are being privileged. It encourages reflection on the designer's positionality and on the potential tension between professional agendas and participants' self-defined priorities. By doing so, the canvas supports a more reflexive practice of empowerment: one that recognises autonomy and collective agency as relational achievements rather than outcomes to be delivered.

2.5 Embodied ethics

Discussions of embodied ethics (Pullen and Rhodes 2014) and embodied generosity (Diprose 2002) are important theoretical starting points for this article. According to Pullen and Rhodes (2022, 4), embodied ethics, as outlined by Diprose (2002), is defined as an embodied and affective experience arising between people, based on social relations and being in a community, rather than being rationally regulated. Pullen and Rhodes (ibid.) suggest that ethics emerge from the openness and mutual generosity between bodies. In organisations, embodied generosity can enable identity work, where one's identity is expressed and produced in interaction with others. Embodied generosity means mutual interaction and openness, as well as taking responsibility for the other, rather than merely defining ethical behaviour through organisational rules (ibid.). In social co-design, embodied ethics has a focal role. Social co-design is often practised through workshops where we are physically present within our bodies. Interaction doesn't take place only through words but is often supported by corporeal doing and embodied cues.

Pullen and Rhodes (2014, forthcoming 2025) define the concept of embodied ethics in the context of organisational ethics as a new and dynamic way to view ethics as an embodied experience that occurs without rational planning and responds openly and generously to the needs of others through interpersonal and communal physical interaction. Embodied ethics involves the need to address inequalities and injustices by placing them within the realm of political action. Caring for others through material and physical relationships can enliven human life. Ethical initiatives can be politically interpreted so that in seeking justice, we care for each other through action. This can be realised through activism, communal gatherings, and democratic participation. This takes place in workplaces and organisations as people strive for better living conditions and resist oppression, inequality, and injustice. Conceptually, embodied ethics includes the idea of acting for the benefit of others as an affective and bodily feeling that arises from within us. Acting for the benefit of others is guided by responding to the needs of people. Ethics is realised as productive action that helps, protects, and cares for others or avoids harmful relationships.

Dale and Latham (2015) introduce the concept of entangled embodiment, which suggests that bodies, materiality, and organisational practices are intertwined. These entanglements

are not fixed but change dynamically and are heterogeneous and interdependent. Organisational practices shape bodies. Bodies are influenced by the cultures of the organisation. Individuals try to navigate these practices. This can lead to ethical questions and reflection on the significance of power for embodied entanglement. The practices that affect bodies are not neutral (ibid.).

These insights on embodied ethics and embodied generosity inform the ethical canvas by emphasising that ethical reflection in co-design is not only cognitive, but also bodily and affective. The canvas encourages designers to pay attention to the embodied dimensions of co-design encounters, including gestures, atmospheres, and emotional responses that shape relationships and decisions. It emphasises the importance of openness and mutual responsiveness between participants, understanding ethics as something that arises through shared presence and interaction rather than through predefined rules. By drawing on embodied generosity, the canvas invites designers to consider how care, reciprocity, and responsibility are expressed through bodily presence, material practices, and the affective tone of collaboration. Figure 1 summarises the four ethical lenses introduced in Section 2 and illustrates how they relate to one another in forming the ethical foundation of the canvas.

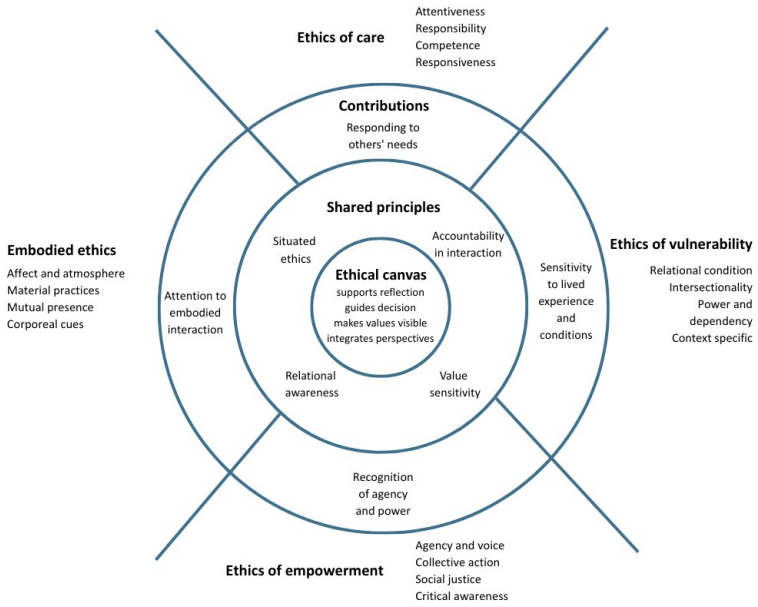


Figure 1 Overview of the four ethical lenses and their relationship to the ethical canvas.

3. Method

The SCD processes informing this research were part of the Integration and Language Learning Living Lab (i4L) at the Laurea University of Applied Sciences in Finland, where Lydén has led socially oriented co-design activities for several years with immigrants and community partners. The analysis also builds on the authors' wider experience in socially engaged design and research across academic and practice contexts. Initially, the aim was to write an ethical evaluation of past co-design processes, using four intersecting ethical lenses: ethics of care, ethics of vulnerability, ethics of empowerment, and embodied ethics. These

lenses were selected for their relevance to collaborative, socially motivated design, particularly in contexts involving marginalised or structurally disadvantaged communities.

The key processes described in this study have been carried out in several EU funded projects and have aimed towards co-designing ways to help immigrants integrate into the host society. (I4L Projects – Laurea, n.d.).

The projects have involved the development of several co-designed interventions, such as explorations into novel ways of opening space for building trust and discussions, including cooking and eating together or caring for horses, and a serious game for supporting discussions on immigrants' integration into work life.

The main types of SCD in the projects were workshops, interviews and prototyping.

The workshops were documented by taking photographs of the process during the work, recording all co-design artefacts (such as drawings, LEGO® buildings, writing and sticky notes) by photographing them, and writing reflective notes afterwards. The interviews were recorded and transcribed. The observations were recorded on forms and complemented by photographs.

All SCD processes have been developed and implemented in collaboration with relevant stakeholders such as immigrants (114), employers (16), non-governmental organisations (NGOs, 25), public service providers (22) and educational institutions (14). A total of 269 persons and 77 organisations have participated in the SCD. Participants and SCD details are listed in Table 1.

Table 1 SCD processes.

SCD group	Participants	(Average) duration, hrs	Community partners	Method and/or topic
Virtual SCD (7 sessions)	40	2 (x7)	5 NGOs, 7 public, 12 education, 16 employer	Journey maps, employment
SCD2	31	3	1 NGO, 2 public	Journey maps, employment
SCD3	8	3	1 public	LSP, employment
SCD4	2	2	2 public	Stakeholder mapping, integration
SCD5	20	2	4 NGOs	Game prototype 1, employment
SCD6	16	3	4 NGOs	Cooking, cards; employment
SCD7	25	n.a.	n.a.	Interviews, employment
SCD8	16	2	1 public	LSP, employment
SCD9	36	2	2 public, 2 education, 1 NGO	Game prototype 2, employment
SCD10	13	2	1 NGO	Mentoring process, employment
SCD11	12	2	1 NGO	Horse assisted integration
SCD12	12	2	1 NGO	Horse assisted integration

SCD13	9	2	n.a.	Game prototype 3, employment
SCD14	11	2	1 NGOs	Game prototype 3, employment
SCD15	18	3,5	2 NGOs 2 public	Gigamapping, integration
Total:	269	44,5 hrs	77	

Across the SCD sessions listed in Table 1, several types of outcomes supported the authors' subsequent reflection. These included practical insights into participation and inclusion, reflections from participants and community partners, ethically significant moments related to recruitment, consent, power relations and communication, and observations about the conditions that strengthened or weakened trust.

As Lydén revisited these cases, the focus shifted from retrospective evaluation to identifying ethically significant moments of decision-making. She reflected on what to disclose, which decisions to highlight, and how to articulate the ethical complexity of each case. This reflection revealed a broader potential. The structure of the evaluation could be repurposed as a planning and assessment tool for other socially oriented designers.

The canvas began to take shape through an initial dialogue with a conversational AI (Microsoft Copilot), which helped identify some of the key dimensions and prompts. The work was then continued independently by Lydén.

Before this publication, the canvas has been shared with design practitioners and researchers for feedback. This feedback has been used in refining the structure, language and usability of the canvas. The feedback process was informal and dialogic, involving conversations and written comments.

The development of the ethical canvas was grounded in reflective practice rather than empirical research involving new participants. However, the co-design processes that informed the canvas involved extensive collaboration with individuals and communities, and ethical care was taken throughout. Informed consent was obtained from all participants involved in these processes. In most cases, this was written. Where literacy or language proficiency mismatch was a concern, verbal consent was recorded, and interpreters were used.

4. Ethical canvas for SCD

The ethical canvas for social co-design supports socially oriented co-design processes. It can be used by individual practitioners and researchers for ethical reflection and planning, or by teams and with community partners for collaboration and decision-making. The user is instructed to revisit and update the canvas iteratively, as the process evolves.

The canvas is designed to be used directly on the Miro platform. The topics can be used in real-life collaboration, either with a note-taking facilitator or using sticky notes or large printouts of the template. The canvas is presented as a Miro template in the Miroverse. It is publicly available at https://miro.com/miroverse/ethical-canvas-for-social-codesign/ and will be updated in future iterations.

Designers and other practitioners without access to Miro can request the template in PDF format from the corresponding author free of charge.

The canvas includes instructions for use and nine main topics, listed in Table 2. The user is instructed to start with sections A-C to define the context and scope of the project, and then either move through the sections in order, or jump to the ones most relevant to the current stage of the process.

Table 2 The topics of the ethical canvas for SCD

Topic	Main content
A) Project overview	Goal, timeframe, setting and artefacts
B) Ethical intent	Purpose, beneficiaries, ethical lenses and ethical sensitivity, key ethical questions, research integrity
C) Context and constraints	Policy, language ecology, accessibility, logistics, sustainability
D) Participants and roles	Recruitment, inclusion criteria, support, compensation, communication, barriers, community partners, capacity
E) Power and positionality	Positionality, impact of position, power map
F) Stewardship	Comprehension, consent, reciprocity, psychological safety, responsibility, availability, risks
G) Activities and boundary objects	Activities, materials, boundary objects, timing, flexibility, adaptation
H) Outcomes, continuity and learning	Intended outcomes, unintended consequences, distribution of benefits, relational impacts, longevity, feedback and sustainability
I) Exit plan	Sustaining relationships and accountability, honouring commitments, assessing ethical intentions, documenting lessons learned, recording decisions

Figure 2 shows an example of the layout and current iteration of the canvas.

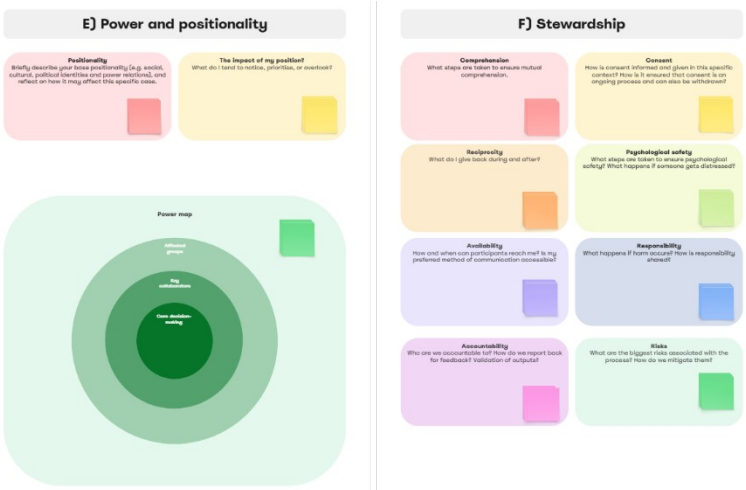


Figure 2 Excerpt from the ethical canvas prototype phase showing sections on power and positionality and stewardship with guiding prompts.

5. Discussion

The ethical canvas presented in this paper was developed through reflective practice and theoretical synthesis. It responds to a recognised need for more situated and relational approaches to ethical awareness in socially oriented co-design.

The development of the ethical canvas demonstrates how theoretical perspectives can be translated into design practice. Each of the four ethical lenses informed both the structure and content of the canvas. The *ethics of care* guided attention to relational processes and mutual responsiveness. The *ethics of vulnerability* framed participants' experiences as relational rather than focused on deficit. The *ethics of empowerment* oriented the tool toward supporting agency and shared decision-making, and *embodied ethics* reminded us that reflection is not purely cognitive but arises through bodily presence and interaction. These theories are thus not only analytical frames but also design principles shaping the creation and use of the canvas.

For users, the canvas invites ethical reflection as an ongoing, situated practice rather than a checklist for compliance. In this sense, it materialises care and vulnerability within the co-design process itself, transforming theory into a collaborative, lived practice.

Formal testing or a structured evaluation was not carried out prior to submitting the paper, which is a limitation of this research. As such, the canvas should be considered a prototype: a theoretically grounded tool that invites further development, adaptation and validation through use.
The cases inspiring this canvas are focused on immigrant integration within a Northern European context. Other contexts might reveal different themes and topics. The authors expect, based on initial feedback, that the canvas could be used more generally in development projects within the social context. It was suggested in the initial feedback round, that it could also be used by students to learn about ethical thinking and collaborative design processes. It would be an interesting continuation of the research to explore the different contexts and uses.

Based on initial feedback, the canvas could benefit from a more systemic or planetary viewpoint. Some changes were made to better incorporate these perspectives, but the work will continue in further iterations. It was also suggested that especially for people with no theoretical background in ethics, the canvas is difficult to use. Accessibility of the canvas needs to be improved. As for now, the canvas should be seen as an extension of this paper and thus the user will hopefully gain at least a basic understanding of the theoretical background needed in their reflection.

The future development of the canvas will include examining how it works in practice. The first stage of this evaluation will focus on usability and clarity by observing facilitated use of the canvas and collecting short reflections from designers and community partners on its comprehensibility and relevance. A later stage will explore the depth and quality of ethical reflection that the canvas supports, including how users articulate values, power relations and responsibilities across the nine topics. Over time, the evaluation will consider whether the canvas contributes to more consistent ethical awareness in planning and facilitation within social co-design. Findings from these phases will inform further iterations of the canvas.

The conversational development of the canvas with an AI tool raises questions about authorship and agency. The tool was used to support articulation and synthesis, not to generate content independently. The authors retained full control over the framing, interpretation and final structure of the canvas, ensuring that it reflects situated knowledge and lived experience.

6. Conclusion

This paper introduced a theoretically grounded and practical prototype for ethical reflection in social co-design. The ethical canvas operationalises the ethics of care, vulnerability, empowerment and embodiment into a format that supports ethical awareness and decision-making in design. For practitioners, this means that ethical reflection becomes a shared material activity, enabling negotiations of values, power and responsibilities. For researchers and educators, it provides a way to bridge theory and practice, demonstrating how ethical concepts can guide design processes from inception to completion.

Initial feedback suggests the canvas holds promise both as a practical tool in development projects and as a pedagogical aid. Future work will focus on further testing, accessibility, and expanding its conceptual scope. The authors invite practitioners, researchers, and anyone with an interest in the ethics of collaborative design to participate in the development of this prototype into a usable and inclusive tool.

Acknowledgements: The authors wish to thank Berenice Rivera-Macias, Meron Yohannes, Alina Leminen, Antonina Petrovic, Annika Schulman, Pia Nummila, Andra-Marta Babre, Ieva Zeiferte, and Laura Tahvanainen for their work in participating in the facilitation of the workshops and other codesign activities, along with Emilia Risu, Reija Arnberg, Kaisla Saastamoinen and other colleagues for their thoughtful feedback on the early prototypes.

Statement: During the preparation of this work ChatGPT v4 and v5, and Microsoft Copilot were used for editing the text, ensuring readability and spelling. Copilot was used in the development of the canvas to support the initial ideation of its content. After using these tools, the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the publication. This research is partly funded by the EU through the projects MAKU, CeMeWE and VOIKO.

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About the Authors:

Hilkka Lydén is a Senior Specialist and manager of the Integration and Language Learning Living Lab at Laurea University of Applied Sciences in Finland. She is a doctoral researcher at the University of Lapland, focusing on social co-design with immigrants.

Soile Juujärvi is a principal lecturer at Laurea and adjunct professor in social psychology at the University of Helsinki. Her research interests include moral development, professional ethics and digital exclusion. She advances participatory research approaches in her work.

Satu Miettinen is the Dean of the Faculty of Art and Design and a Professor of Service Design at the University of Lapland in Finland. She is recognised as one of the pioneers in the field of service design.